James Zhang | HZB3M | Print-friendly backup

Hot Gossip · A Virtual Exhibit · Grade 11 Philosophy

The Murdered Master of Light

Suhrawardi was a Persian philosopher who used the idea of light to explain reality and our awareness of ourselves. [1] In 1186, he completed his main work, *The Philosophy of Illumination* . [2] A few years later, he was executed after being accused of heresy, or going against accepted religious beliefs. [3] His ideas continued to be studied in the Islamic world, but remained less known in Europe. [4] Why has a philosopher with such influential ideas received so little attention in Western philosophy classes?

Full name: Shihāb ad-Dīn Yaḥyā ibn Ḥabash ibn Amīrak as-Suhrawardī [5]

Titles: *Shaykh al-Ishraq* (“Master of Illumination”) and *al-Maqtul* (“the Killed”) [6]

Born: Around 1154 or 1155, in the village of Suhraward, northwestern Iran [7]

Died: End of 1191 or early 1192, in Aleppo, Syria; executed after being accused of heresy [8]

Main work: *The Philosophy of Illumination* (*Hikmat al-Ishraq*), completed in 1186 [9]

Timeline

c. 1154 or 1155 Born in Suhraward, northwestern Iran. [10]

1183 Arrives in Aleppo and gains the support of Prince al-Zahir, son of Saladin. [11]

1186 Completes *The Philosophy of Illumination* . [12]

1191 or early 1192 Executed in Aleppo. [13]

1200s–1600s Scholars in the Islamic world continue to study and comment on his work, including Mulla Sadra (d. 1636). [14]

Mid-1900s Henry Corbin edits, translates, and studies his works, bringing him more attention from Western scholars. [15]

What happened in Aleppo

Suhrawardi gained the support of al-Zahir, the ruler of Aleppo, but came into conflict with some of the city’s religious scholars. He was accused of heresy, meaning that his teachings were considered to go against accepted religious beliefs. [16] Both religious disagreements and political tensions contributed to the conflict surrounding his execution. However, historians disagree about the exact accusations and circumstances of his death. [17]

Why You've Probably Never Heard of Him

Reason 1

His works were not translated into Latin during the Middle Ages.

Many European scholars encountered Arabic philosophy through Latin translations. [18] Suhrawardi's works were not translated into Latin during this period, which limited their influence in medieval Europe. [19]

Reason 2

He remained important in the Islamic world.

Scholars continued studying and discussing his ideas for centuries. [20] His limited recognition in Western philosophy does not mean that he was forgotten everywhere. It shows that different traditions recognize different thinkers as central to philosophy.

Reason 3

He has often been presented mainly as a mystic.

Suhrawardi explored spiritual understanding, but he also developed philosophical arguments and challenged earlier thinkers. [21] Focusing only on his mystical ideas can cause his other contributions to be overlooked.

Room One

Bodies, Light, and Understanding

How did Suhrawardi understand physical things?

Suhrawardi described physical bodies as “dark barriers,” or *barzakh* . This does not mean that every object looks dark or cannot shine. He distinguished the physical body from the light present in or on it. In his philosophy, a body is not itself the same thing as light. [22]

Light also means more than visible brightness in his philosophy. Suhrawardi used it to explain awareness and knowledge, which we will explore in the next rooms. [23]



Can a definition fully explain something?

Aristotle and Ibn Sina

Aristotle and Ibn Sina used definitions to explain what things are. [24] For example, defining a human as a “rational animal” identifies humans as animals with the ability to reason. [25]

Suhrawardi

Suhrawardi questioned whether these definitions could give us complete understanding. He argued that light is already evident and does not need a definition to make it clearer. As he wrote, “Since there is nothing more evident than light, there is nothing less in need of definition.” [26]

Consider the difference between reading a description of a taste and experiencing it yourself. This example helps illustrate how knowing something directly can differ from knowing its description. Suhrawardi still valued logical reasoning, but he also emphasized direct awareness. [27]

Room Two

Reality, Sorted by Light

Where do we fit in Suhrawardi's view of reality?

Suhrawardi used light to explain the structure of reality. He distinguished between nonphysical lights, visible light, and physical bodies. These categories help explain the relationship between God, souls, and the physical world. [28]

Nonphysical light

The Light of Lights

Suhrawardi called God the "Light of Lights," the ultimate source on which everything else depends. [29] This does not mean a physical light, like the Sun.

Nonphysical lights

Higher lights

These are nonphysical intellects within his system. They depend on the Light of Lights and form part of the order between God and the physical world. [30]

Nonphysical lights

Human souls

Suhrawardi understood the human soul as a nonphysical light that is aware of itself and governs the body. [31] Calling it a light does not mean that it visibly glows.

A different category · not a nonphysical light

Visible light and physical bodies

Visible light exists in physical things. Bodies themselves belong to a different category, which Suhrawardi called "dark barriers." [32] A body is therefore not simply a weaker version of a soul.

What does "brightness" mean here?

Suhrawardi described nonphysical lights as differing in intensity and perfection. [33] Brightness helps illustrate this philosophical order; it is not a scientific measurement or a way to rank people's worth.

Room Two: Additional Detail

Optional: Suhrawardi’s four categories (more technical)

Suhrawardi sorted existing things using two questions: Is it light or dark? Does it exist in itself, or only in something else? [34] “Exists in itself” here does not mean independent of God. In his system, everything depends on the Light of Lights. [35] The four categories are explained below.

Light · exists in itself

Nonphysical lights

Lights that are not physical and do not exist in something else. This group includes the Light of Lights, the higher lights, and human souls. All of them except the Light of Lights depend on a higher source.

Light · exists only in something else

Accidental lights

Light that exists only in something else. Visible light in physical bodies is one kind. Suhrawardi also described accidental lights in nonphysical lights, not only in bodies.

Dark · exists in itself

Dark barriers

Physical bodies. A body is not a light, and it depends on light to become manifest, or show itself.

Dark · exists only in something else

Dark accidents

Nonluminous qualities that exist in something else, including qualities of physical bodies.

Room Three

How Do You Know Yourself?

Suhrawardi: direct awareness of the self

Suhrawardi argued that we are directly aware of ourselves. [36] You do not need to look in a mirror or examine your body to know that you are experiencing a thought or feeling.

This illustrates what is called “knowledge by presence”: knowing directly, rather than through a description or outside evidence. [37] It does not mean that you know everything about your personality. It means that your awareness of yourself does not depend on first observing yourself from the outside.

Suhrawardi described this self as a nonphysical light that is aware of itself. [38]

Hume: a collection of experiences

David Hume offered a different explanation. When he looked inward, he found particular thoughts, feelings, and sensations, but no separate, unchanging self. [39] He described people as “a bundle or collection of different perceptions.” [40]

Two ways of understanding who we are

For Hume, looking inward reveals changing experiences. For Suhrawardi, we know ourselves directly as the ones having those experiences. [41]

Question for visitors

Which view better explains your sense of self? Are you a collection of changing experiences, a self that is directly aware of them, or do you find something convincing in both views?

The Ontario Connection

Am I the Same Person in Every Situation?

My personal application · James Zhang

As a student in Ontario, I notice that I act differently depending on the situation. I am usually quieter in class but more talkative with friends. Even with different groups of friends, I may show different sides of my personality. This makes me question whether acting differently means that I am a different person.

I find something convincing in both Hume's and Suhrawardi's views. Hume's focus on changing thoughts, feelings, and experiences connects to how I behave differently in different settings. [42] Suhrawardi's idea of direct self-awareness connects to my sense that I am still aware of myself as the person having those experiences. [43]

These ideas also affect how I think about others in my school. The way someone acts in one class may show only part of who they are. In an Ontario classroom where students have different backgrounds and experiences, we should be careful about judging someone's whole identity from one situation.

Endnotes

1. Roxanne Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* , substantive revision March 29, 2019, secs. 3.2 and 4.2, https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/suhrawardi/ .

2. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

3. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

4. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” introduction and sec. 6.1.

5. Britannica Editors, “as-Suhrawardī,” *Encyclopaedia Britannica* , accessed October 14, 2026, https://www.britannica.com/biography/as-Suhrawardi .

6. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1; Britannica Editors, “as-Suhrawardī.”

7. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1, gives “around 1154”; Britannica Editors, “as-Suhrawardī,” gives c. 1155.

8. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

9. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

10. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1; Britannica Editors, “as-Suhrawardī.”

11. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

12. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

13. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

14. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 6.1.

15. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” introduction and sec. 1.2.

16. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

17. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 1.1.

18. Dag Nikolaus Hasse, “Influence of Arabic and Islamic Philosophy on the Latin West,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* , substantive revision December 3, 2025, sec. 1, https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/arabic-islamic-influence/ .

19. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” introduction.

20. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 6.1.

21. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” secs. 2.2 and 6.2.

22. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” secs. 3 and 4.2.

23. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2.

24. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 2.2.

25. Britannica Editors, “Predicable,” *Encyclopaedia Britannica* , accessed October 14, 2026, https://www.britannica.com/topic/predicable .

26. Suhrawardi, *The Philosophy of Illumination* , §107, quoted in Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 2.2.

27. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” secs. 2.1 and 3.2.

28. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.

29. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.

30. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.
31. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” secs. 3.1 and 3.2.
32. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.
33. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” secs. 2.1 and 4.2.
34. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.
35. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 4.2.
36. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2.
37. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2.
38. Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2, discussing and quoting Suhrawardi, *The Philosophy of Illumination* , §127.
39. David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–40), bk. 1, pt. 4, sec. 6, paras. 2–3, Hume Texts Online, accessed October 14, 2026, https://davidhume.org/texts/t/1/4/6 .
40. Hume, *Treatise* , bk. 1, pt. 4, sec. 6, para. 4.
41. Hume, *Treatise* , bk. 1, pt. 4, sec. 6, paras. 3–4; Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2.
42. For Hume’s account of the mind as changing perceptions, see Hume, *Treatise* , bk. 1, pt. 4, sec. 6, para. 4.
43. For Suhrawardi’s account of self-awareness, see Marcotte, “Suhrawardi,” sec. 3.2.

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